all, it's in our interest for the platform to succeed with our show."

Nair has his work cut out to deliver a solid slate again in 2026. To do it when the streaming industry itself is going through a churn means a tough act, but Applause is ready for the challenge. In the pipeline is Hansal Mehta's *Gandhi*, another instalment of *Scam* and *Undekhi*, and a new show by Nitya Mehra. There will also be a bigger push for theatrical, with films by Imtiaz Ali, Pa. Ranjith, Kabir Khan and Jay Mehta lined up. "We want to do big theatrical entertainers, entertaining cinema which will have some message. I am not telling you what to think, but it's a film that makes you think," he says.

The studio has also acquired Jeffrey Archer's novels to adapt into films and series and is using AI to adapt more of the Amar Chitra Katha catalogue on its YouTube channel. As Applause continues adapting books and international shows—a strategy that has paid dividends for the most part—Nair is confident that the OTT wave isn't going anywhere. "There's no slowdown or downturn, there's no putting this genie back in the bottle," he says. Viewers aren't complaining. ■

—Suhani Singh



BIG DEBUT Karan Joshi (right), who plays the titular part in *Laalo: Krishna Sada Sahaayate*

CINEMA ▼

A Divine Turn

A modest, newcomer-led Gujarati film about faith and self-realisation has struck gold at the box office

Laalo, an auto driver in Gujarat's Junagadh, falls into bad company and takes to alcohol and smoking. The lure of quick money sees him entrapped in a house, with no help in sight. Just when all hope is gone, in enters Lord Krishna. Only he isn't blue-faced and performs no miracle. In fact, he looks like an ordinary Indian man. That's the premise of Gujarati film *Laalo: Krishna Sada Sahaayate*, billed as a "divine blockbuster" after becoming the highest-grossing film in the language, with collections crossing Rs 100 crore. On January 9, a Hindi-dubbed version arrived in cinemas.

Its success is noteworthy given that behind it is a crew of underdogs: the director, writers, musician and lyricist are all newcomers. It's the first on-screen credit for Karan Joshi, who plays the titular part. "We dreamt that we'd come to Mumbai with our film, but we didn't think it'd happen in our first film itself," says Ankit Sakhiya, whose college friends pooled in the money and became first-time producers in the process.

> "THE FILM GIVES NEW FILMMAKERS **FAITH IN THEIR STORIES**," SAYS REEVA RACHH, WHO PLAYS LAALO'S WIFE

Through *Laalo...*, Sakhiya intended to both focus on ethics and "activate the self-realisation mode" of audiences. Shruhad Goswami, who gets to be the guiding light, has seen the film's impact, with audiences in tears. "Here they see God in the form of a friend who makes us understand," he says.

The film's a game-changer for Gujarati cinema, giving a much-needed fillip to the small film industry. "So far, we used to keep hearing that Gujarati audiences don't show up at theatres, so we cannot experiment or tell our stories," says Reeva Rachh, who plays Laalo's wife. "The film gives new filmmakers faith in their stories."

Meanwhile, Sakhiya's producer friends are keen to collaborate and hit the jackpot again. "The responsibility has increased," he says. "Everyone feels like I am their best friend or brother. But I have to start from scratch." ■

—Suhani Singh